

“The beauty of e-sports is that they don’t have a gender barrier. Different leagues for men and women would be great for financial incentives, but if we do that, we are like any other sport”

NIMISH RAUT, *Global Head of Esports: Partnerships & Special Projects at NODWIN Gaming*

says, “My parents still think it is stupid, but because I have a career, they let me do whatever I want to.”

The online gaming community can be cruel, and especially so if you’re a woman. Remarks on attire or appearance, or mock-surprise at finding a girl gaming and not in the kitchen, are common. “They have a beauty standard they want to fit a girl gamer into,” says Tarushika. Sonali was once told that if she turned off her face cam, nobody would watch her stream. Says she, “When a woman loses a game, it’s because of her gender.” If she wins, reactions range from disbelief to admiration. Kaashvi’s claim to fame came after she defeated a top male gamer in Call of Duty. “He was streaming at the time and said, ‘She cannot be real, my opponent is a hacker’. Thankfully, I had recorded my perspective and uploaded it on YouTube.” The video went viral and motivated her to give up a high-paying finance job and take up gaming full-time. Top streamers can earn up to Rs 5-10 lakh a month, depending on how many online followers and brand deals they have.

“We come from a cultural mindset that believes ‘*Ladki hone ke baavjood bhi* (despite being a girl) she is winning’,” says Nimish Raut, global head of Esports: Partnerships & Special Projects at NODWIN Gaming. It’s this pervasive misogyny that has made popular streamers like Shagufta Iqbal, 30, (a.k.a Xyya) from Thane, prefer to hide their name or not use a mic in multiplayer rounds. Saloni has even seen a man quit a mixed team because he “cannot play with a woman”.

Saloni Pawar, 26
Content creator from Dombivali

Gaming avatar: Meow16

Play time: 9-12 hours daily

“It is very tough to balance content creation and being an esports athlete. If I were only the latter, I’d need to have a side gig because currently playing professionally doesn’t pay much”

MANDAR DEODHAR

